CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

DEVOPS ENGINEER IN THE AI ERA

AI writes the code now — somebody still has to keep the systems it runs on alive at 3 a.m. That somebody is hired as a feeder first, and a DevOps engineer second.

★ TL;DR — Median around $130K — developer anchor $135,980, sysadmin anchor $99,130 (BLS) — but there is NO direct door. DevOps is a second seat: you enter through a feeder job at $76–99K and reach the title at year 3–5, which is why study prints 4+ years. The catch is not the pay. It's the calendar every course ad lies about. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$130K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK MEDIUM

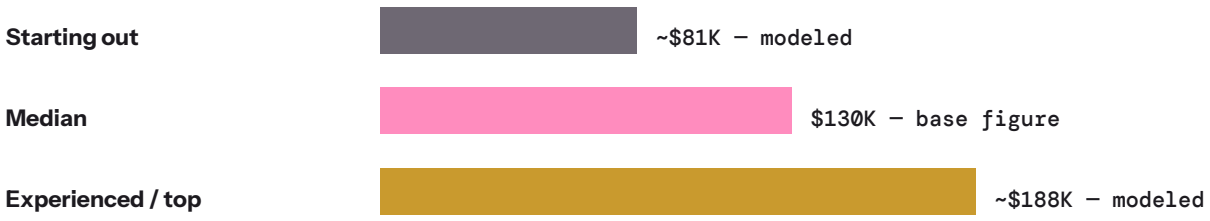
- DevOps is a destination, not a door: an analysis of fifteen years of Hacker News hiring threads found just 0.50% of operations postings asked for a junior — and zero in 2024 and 2025. The flagship credentials agree: AWS's DevOps Professional expects 2+ years of experience, and Azure's Expert cannot be awarded without the Associate credential first.

- The feeder ladder is real, paid and hiring: Software Developers — typical entry bachelor's, experience required: none — carry ~106,100 openings a year combined at +10% growth. Enter developer-side or cloud-side, where the growth anchor lives, not on legacy on-prem skills alone: BLS projects sysadmins at −4% precisely because their tasks are migrating to DevOps-focused developers.

- AI agents absorb the junior task list — AWS DevOps Agent and PagerDuty's SRE Agent triage incidents, execute runbooks and draft remediations, and assistants write the pipeline YAML. That's exactly why the entry is a feeder job that still hires humans, not a certificate: the agents removed the remaining reason to invent a junior DevOps rung.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for DevOps Engineer is a ~$130K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A DEVOPS ENGINEER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Build and maintain cloud infrastructure in AWS, Azure or GCP
- ✓ Automate deployments with CI/CD pipelines and infrastructure-as-code
- ✓ Monitor systems and respond when production breaks
- ✓ Help developers ship faster without setting anything on fire

Think: the road crew and air-traffic control of software — nobody notices you until the day everything stops.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI writes Terraform, YAML and scripts, drafts runbooks, and — since 2026 — works incidents itself: the AWS DevOps Agent correlates telemetry, code changes and deployment history to find root causes and recommend mitigations. Configuration and triage busywork is being absorbed quickly.	Architecture trade-offs, security judgment, and calm decision-making during an outage with money burning. Incident accountability stays human — the agents recommend; a person owns the call.

⚠ **A DevOps certificate as your FIRST credential is a ticket to a door that isn't hiring juniors — the Professional/Expert exams themselves recommend 2+ years of experience, and the Azure Expert literally cannot be awarded before the Associate beneath it. Feeder pay is $76–99K; anyone quoting you the $130K title figure as a starting salary is selling the destination as the door.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Senior-level pay and full remote ✓ Deep, compounding technical skill ✓ Every company with software needs you — once you can already do the work	✗ On-call rotations — production does not respect weekends ✗ You inherit everyone's infrastructure sins ✗ Certifications expire; the treadmill never stops

Good fit? You're a systems thinker who stays calm when things break, likes automating yourself out of repetitive work — and accepts a paid apprenticeship in a feeder seat first.
Bad fit? You want the DevOps title as your first tech job, or predictable, interruption-free days once you have it. Incidents are the job description.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE FEEDER ROUTE FROM IT / SYSADMIN	DOOR B — THE FEEDER ROUTE FROM DEVELOPER
The standard feeder: cloud support, network support or sysadmin work (support medians $62,890–$76,220; sysadmin occupation median $99,130), with automation practised from the first role — Python/Bash, Git, infrastructure-as-code, CI/CD. Your ops past plus automation depth is the credential the DevOps title actually screens for.	Software engineers slide in by owning their team's pipelines, infrastructure and observability until the platform title follows. This side enters through the growing anchor — developers at +10% with ~106,100 openings a year — and code-first DevOps hires are prized for automation depth.

Smart move: Build a home lab that mimics a real company: a small app, CI/CD, monitoring, one deliberate outage you fix and document. It's not a substitute for the feeder job — it's how you win the feeder job, and interviewers can smell a real lab from a tutorial copy.
Where you land after: Senior DevOps / platform engineer → site reliability leadership or cloud architecture — reached at year 3–5 via the feeder, at the verified ~$130K mid-career figure.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
PICK YOUR	LAND THE	AUTOMATE FROM	EARN THE	TAKE PLATFORM	MOVE TO

STEP 1 — Pick your feeder door

FREE · WEEK 1

- Choose your first job, not your final title: junior software developer, cloud/network support, or sysadmin associate.
- Rate your Linux, networking and Git honestly; gaps here sink everything later, in every feeder.

STEP 2 — Land the feeder job

JOB SEARCH · MONTHS 1-6

- Apply to the anchor occupations that hire beginners at scale — developers (experience required: none) and support roles (~48,700 openings a year).
- Budget feeder pay of $76–99K. This seat is the roadmap; the title comes later.

STEP 3 — Automate from inside the feeder seat

PAID · YEAR 1

- Script everything repeatable in your role: Python or Bash, Git discipline, first Terraform, first CI/CD pipeline.
- Sysadmin-only legacy skills aim at a −4% anchor — steer every project toward the cloud/developer side.

STEP 4 — Earn the Associate-tier credential

PAID · YEAR 1-2

- AWS Developer Associate or CloudOps Associate, AZ-104, or GCP Associate Cloud Engineer — with production exposure underneath.
- Associate is the correct rung now. The Professional/Expert exams belong to step 6, where their experience recommendations are met.

STEP 5 — Take platform responsibility

PAID · YEAR 2-3

- Own pipelines, observability and incident response for a real team; 'junior DevOps' and platform-associate seats price at 1+ year of feeder experience — that's you now.
- Document incidents and post-mortems: judgment under pressure is the portfolio seniors screen for.

STEP 6 — Move to the DevOps title

PAID · YEAR 3-5

- Apply to DevOps Engineer roles at the posting standard: 3–5 years of combined dev/ops experience.
- Sit the Professional/Expert credential (AWS DOP-C02, AZ-400) here — as the capstone it was designed to be.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: spin up a free-tier cloud account, deploy anything end to end — and write down which feeder door you're entering through.

□ Days 1–30: Linux and networking gaps closed daily; feeder applications out; cloud fundamentals study started.

□ Days 31–60: Terraform managing your lab; first CI/CD pipeline live; feeder interviews in progress.

□ Days 61–90: monitoring and a documented outage drill done; Associate-tier cert study underway, timed for after the feeder seat.

□ Day 90: a documented home platform and a feeder seat landed or in final rounds — the DevOps clock is now honestly running.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ HOPE IS NOT A DEPLOYMENT STRATEGY. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.